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Term paper

on the topic:

“Why Young Men Turn to the Far Right: The Effects of Gendered Economic Attitudes on Far-Right Voting”

Name: Iuliia Peskischeva

Student ID number: 13033095

eMail: Iuliia.Peskischeva@campus.lmu.de

Introduction

Something is shifting in the political preferences of Europe's youngest male voters: while their female peers move leftward, young men are increasingly drawn to far-right parties, opening a gender gap that has no precedent among older generations. Though the general trend in the rise in support for the far-right in Europe between 2019 and 2024 has been similar for both men and women across the age groups, it is the rise in support among young men in particular that is striking. Milosav et al.'s (2025) study, which uses Age-Period-Cohort analysis on European Election Studies data from 1989–2024, finds that the gender gap for far-right parties is actually a generational, rather than life cycle, phenomenon. The study finds that among older generations, such as baby boomers, there is little gender difference in support for far-right parties, but among Gen Z, there is a significant and increasing gender gap between men and women. Moreover, it finds that this divergence accelerates faster among members of Gen Z as they age in their 20s compared to previous generations (Milosav et al., 2025). It is not only that young men are more likely than young women to vote for the far-right parties. The research shows that they are also more likely to *consider* voting for the far-right parties in the future, and the rate at which this gap increases is also higher than for any other generation (Abou-Chadi, 2024). The explained trends are especially disconcerting when viewed in light of the well-established finding in political sociology that younger generations have more progressive values than their forebears (Inglehart, 1971; 2016; Rekker, 2024).

Although the existence of a gender gap in voting for the far right among young adults is justified and well-researched, the gendered patterns of this phenomenon and the causes and factors of such voting are poorly investigated, especially with the latest data, including the last ESS wave. ESS Round 11 is remarkably valuable as it was the first time that a special module on gender attitudes was fielded. The module contains many questions assessing hostile and benevolent sexism, gender-based discrimination perceptions, gender equality policies, as well as masculine and feminine identity orientations, but it is precisely the inclusion of items measuring perceptions of gender relations in the labor market that motivates the use of this data in the present study as it opens up new opportunities for testing hypotheses based on political economy of gender inequality theory, which provides a theoretical foundation for this paper.

Aside from the theoretical significance of the study, the research has practical importance as well. Knowledge of the drivers of young men's support for the far right is critical to understanding the development and consolidation of the gender gap in political attitudes. Perhaps the most significant

practical importance of the study is for policymakers, civil society organizations, and political parties. If new gendered factors driving far-right voting are identified, novel approaches to sustaining public support for gender equality agendas can be formulated and implemented in order to draw support away from the far right and prevent further backsliding on gender equality and democratic values in Europe, which is expected as according to research, first-time voting and preferences formed in the early voting years have a significant impact on political views and voting later in life (Milosav et al., 2025).

Considering everything mentioned above, the research on the factors of far-right support among young men is relevant and intriguing. That is what I aim to do in this paper. The research question of my study is based on the political economy theoretical assumptions explained in detail in the “Theoretical framework” section and is the following: “To what extent are young European men's voting for far-right parties driven by perceived economic costs of gender equality?”.

Existing literature and hypotheses

Factors of far-right support

The general individual-level factors of far-right voting in Europe have been a focus of extensive research in the past two decades. The best-studied predictors of far-right voting include anti-immigration attitudes, low education level, male gender, blue-collar occupational status, and political distrust (Mudde, 2007; Ivarsflaten, 2008; Stockemer et al., 2018). However in a landmark meta-analysis of 46 quantitative studies published between 1995 and 2016, Stockemer, Lentz, and Mayer (2018) find that these predictors tend to perform as expected in only about half of the cases, indicating that there is no single "core model" of radical right voting and that multiple pathways to far-right support coexist across different social groups and national contexts. Anti-immigration attitudes remain among the strongest and most consistent predictors in Western Europe (Allen, 2017; Ivarsflaten, 2008), though Allen (2017) shows that in post-communist countries, the far-right electorate is comparatively less driven by anti-immigration sentiment and more by democratic dissatisfaction. Abou-Chadi, T. and Kurer, T. (2021) find that occupational unemployment risk significantly increases the probability of voting for the radical right — and crucially, a partner's unemployment risk within the same household also increases far-right support. Political distrust in supranational governance and Euroscepticism were also established as important distinguishing characteristics of the far-right electorate, and these factors are significant for both eastern and western European voters (Brils et al., 2022). In more recent work, the role of social status threat has been highlighted as a unifying mechanism. Gidron and Hall

(2017) contend that it is not economic hardship per se but the perception of declining subjective social status that drives support for the populist right, and that this mechanism integrates both economic and cultural dimensions of threat, as economic developments and shifting cultural frameworks combine to depress the social standing of men without a college education (Gidron & Hall, 2017).

Gendered perspective on voting for the far right

Within this broader literature, research on age and gender has yielded a particularly striking finding in recent years: the emergence of an unprecedented gender gap in far-right support among the youngest cohort of European voters. This was first systematically documented by Givens (2004), who named the phenomenon “radical right gender gap” (Givens, 2004). Hartevelde et al. (2015) extended the theoretical understanding of the phenomenon by identifying mechanisms of mediation, whereby men and women differ in the characteristics and attitudes that predict far-right voting, and moderation, whereby the same attitudes translate differently into vote choice for men and women. Their findings on 17 Western and Eastern European countries show that women are no less nativist, authoritarian, or discontent with the current political situation than men. However, these attitudes are less strongly associated with radical-right voting among women. This suggests that far-right parties may deter women for reasons beyond their political programme (Hartevelde et al., 2015). More recent studies have examined gender more directly. Coffé et al. (2023) show that sexist attitudes account for half of the relationship between masculinity and support for the populist radical right party VOX among men (Coffé et al., 2023).

Gendered factors of far-right support

A body of studies has recently begun exploring the gendered aspects of the appeal of the far right. A part of these studies examined the gendered economic factors that might contribute to voting for the far right among young men. Off’s (2023) work shows that the more attention given to gender equality issues can spark a conservative reaction that contributes to populist radical right voting. In fact, conservative values on gender predicted voting for the Sweden Democrats in 2018 but not in 2014. It is particularly interesting as 2017-2018 was a period bracketing major feminist mobilisations, including #MeToo (Off, 2023). Lee, S. C. (2025) approached the gap with a political-economic perspective conducting a study in South Korea which demonstrated that economic insecurity among young men within a dualized labour market structure, along with their perceptions of reverse economic discrimination against men through policies of gender equality, was a significant predictor of their support for anti-gender policies and the conservative candidate

in the presidential elections in South Korea in 2022. This finding contradicts a share of research on drivers of young men's support for the far-right and concludes that It is not rooted in nostalgia for traditional gender roles. Young Korean men who participated in the survey are actually liberal when it comes to gender equality as a democratic principle. What seems to fuel their anti-gender backlash is their perception of gender equality policies as being “unfair” to them in a precarious job market. Hence, this study points to *economic factors* as a potential driver of anti-gender backlash (Lee, S. C., 2025). Carbonell (2025) poses a hypothesis similar to Lee's and studies the impact of economic factors on young male voting for the far right qualitatively in a European context. The study argues that the anti-feminist backlash among young men can be seen as more than just a reaction to feminism as a cultural issue, but is linked to their economic insecurity, as traditional markers of masculine identity, such as stable jobs and the provider role, lose meaning with the rise of the gig economy, and homeownership becomes less feasible (Carbonell, 2025). Furthermore, Cabezas's (2022) qualitative study demonstrates that far-right parties like VOX in Spain consistently use frames that appeal to perceptions of threats to masculinity and portray feminism as the enemy of the Spanish people, creating a clear communicative connection between masculine identity and sexist attitudes among voters (Cabezas, M, 2022). Anduiza and Rico (2024) use panel data from Spain and provide evidence that modern sexism, defined as the belief that gender-based discrimination is no longer an issue, is an important predictor of future voting for the far-right party VOX, both as an enduring trait and as an ephemeral response to feminist mobilization (Anduiza & Rico, 2024).

Overall, the literature reviewed above provides a rich foundation. The broad determinants of far-right voting are well mapped, the existence of both a general and a generational gender gap is empirically established, and promising theoretical mechanisms — from cultural backlash to masculinity threat and economic insecurity — have been proposed and tested. Nevertheless, important gaps remain. First, most existing studies either examine the gender gap in far-right voting in general terms or analyse the predictors of far-right support across the electorate as a whole, without isolating young men. Second, although the specifically economic dimension of gendered grievance — the perception that gender equality policies entail personal economic costs for men — has been theorised, it has not been tested comparatively across Europe using individual-level survey data. Third, no previous study has drawn on ESS Round 11 data to investigate gendered economic determinants of far-right support among young men.

Theoretical framework

The theoretical foundation of this study draws on Iversen and Rosenbluth's (2010) political economy of gender inequality, which conceptualises gender relations as shaped by the structure of economic production and the distribution of bargaining power between men and women. In their framework, bargaining power within the household derives from "outside options" — the ability of each spouse to sustain an independent livelihood outside the marriage. Government policies that expand women's labour market opportunities, such as publicly funded childcare, social services, and public sector employment, improve women's outside options and thereby strengthen their bargaining position. Iversen and Rosenbluth note that such policies are partly financed by taxing male breadwinners in traditional families, creating a divergence in interests: working women favour an active state that supports their economic independence, while men in breadwinner roles, and women who depend on them, have less reason to support policies that raise their tax burden without directly improving their household welfare. Iversen and Rosenbluth demonstrate empirically that the resulting conflict of interest between the sexes is most pronounced where female labour force participation is high and where the welfare state actively supports women's economic autonomy, producing a substantial gender gap in support for left-wing parties and expansive employment policies.

The present study extends this line of reasoning by examining its implications from the possible perspective of modern European young men. Iversen and Rosenbluth's theory implies that gender equality policies shift bargaining power toward women. It follows that men who perceive themselves as bearing the economic costs of this shift, particularly those facing labour-market precarity, may come to view gender equality not as a universal good but as a source of personal disadvantage. This perception may render such men receptive to far-right parties that frame gender equality as threatening to men's prospects and promise to defend a traditional gendered order. I also follow Carbonell and assume that young male frustration over losing the breadwinner role, status, and control is the product of these economic grievances. This sentiment is actively politicised and at times enhanced by far-right parties who present feminism as the enemy and offer a restorative vision of masculinity.

It should be noted that Iversen and Rosenbluth do not themselves address far-right voting. Their analysis concerns the mainstream left-right gender gap. The contribution of the present study is to apply their political-economic logic to a phenomenon they did not anticipate: the growing support for far-right parties among young European men.

Building on these theoretical assumptions, I formulate the following hypotheses:

H1: Among young men in European democracies, opposition to gender equality economic policies is positively associated with voting for far-right parties, after controlling for established individual-level predictors of far-right support.

H2: Economic gender attitudes retain a statistically significant association with far-right voting after controlling for *anti-immigration attitudes* — the dominant predictor identified in the existing literature.

H3: Economic gender attitudes have independent explanatory power for far-right voting beyond *hostile sexism* — that is, when both are included in the same model, economic gender attitudes remain a significant predictor of far-right voting.

Data and methods of analysis

However, political economy theory traditionally focuses on structural economic factors that shape political behavior, including voting for far-right parties. In this study, I examine individual-level predictors that capture attitudes toward gendered economic relations instead. I do this for several reasons. First, I contend that these attitudinal measures effectively capture how individuals' perceptions of economic fairness and gender competition are affected by their economic conditions. In this way, they can be thought of as "micro-level" measures of the "macro-level" processes that political economy theory suggests. In this sense, the analysis can be understood as an examination of how structural conditions are internalized and translated into attitudes that, in turn, inform voting behavior. This is, of course, not equivalent to directly measuring country-level effects on individual attitudes, and I do not claim identification of structural factors. Second, this choice of analytical level is motivated by pragmatic considerations of data availability. *ESS Round 11* (2023/24) is an exceptionally valuable dataset for this purpose, as it includes, for the first time, a dedicated and extensive module on gender attitudes — providing novel measures that have not yet been exploited in the far-right voting literature. At the same time, the number of countries in the sample is insufficient for a rigorous multilevel analysis of structural country-level factors, making an individual-level approach both more feasible and more statistically reliable. For this study, I subset the initial ESS data to include only democracies in Europe where far-right parties participated in the elections, excluding Hungary, which has backslid toward autocracy in recent years and is considered "Partly free" according to the latest Freedom House review (Freedom house, 2026). The sample is restricted to male respondents aged 18–34.

Operationalization of variables

The hostile sexism index draws on three items that ask respondents how often they believe: (1) women seek to gain power by getting control over men (wsekpwr), (2) women get easily offended (weasoff), and (3) women exaggerate claims of sexual harassment in the workplace (wexashr). All three items are measured on a 5-point scale ranging from 1 (Never) to 5 (Always). The index is calculated as the arithmetic mean of the mentioned three items.

The gendered economic attitudes index is constructed from four items that capture respondents' perceptions of gender equality in the economic sphere and their support for policy interventions to improve gender equality. The included items measure whether equal pay for women and men is bad or good for the economy (eqpaybg) and whether equal numbers of women and men in higher management positions are bad or good for businesses (eqmgmbg). Both have a 7-point scale ranging from 0 (Very bad) to 6 (Very good). Two further items measure support for policy enforcement: whether the respondent favors or opposes making businesses pay a fine for gender pay gaps (fineqpy) and whether the respondent favors or opposes requiring both parents to take equal periods of paid parental leave (eqparlv). Both are measured on a 5-point scale ranging from 1 (Strongly in favour) to 5 (Strongly against).

Since the component items of the economic gender attitudes index use different response scales (0–6 for the perceived economic impact items and 1–5 for the policy support items), I standardize each item individually to a z-score before averaging, ensuring that all items contribute equally to the composite measure regardless of their original metric. The items eqpaybg and eqmgmbg are reverse-coded prior to standardization so that higher values consistently indicate greater opposition to gender equality in the economic domain. For consistency, the same item-level standardization procedure is applied to the hostile sexism index. The same procedure was implemented for the anti-immigration attitudes variable, as it is also a composite of several items. The political trust variable was calculated as an average of several items measuring trust in political institutions, but no standardization was implemented, as all the items were measured with the same scale.

The dependent variable is coded as 1 if the respondent voted for a far-right party, and 0 otherwise. Far-right parties are identified using the PopuList dataset. The additional search was implemented to verify the relevance of the PopuList data, and if old far-right parties changed names/ideology or new far-right parties emerged and became popular (this happened in Lithuania, for example), the study has accounted for these changes. If several types of voting were captured by the ESS (e.g., for Germany), I included the party-list votes only.

A complete understanding of all implemented data transformations can be obtained by reviewing the Python script in the Appendix.

Since the data has a hierarchical structure, individuals nested within countries, cross-country variation in far-right support is expected due to differences in political systems, party supply, institutional arrangements, and cultural contexts. However, the theoretical interest of this study lies in individual-level attitudinal predictors rather than in estimating country-level effects. I therefore employ logistic regression with country fixed effects, which absorbs all observed and unobserved between-country heterogeneity. This approach ensures that the estimated coefficients capture how variation in gender attitudes among young men within the same national context relates to far-right voting, net of any country-specific factors. I use robust standard errors clustered at the country level to account for potential within-country correlation of residuals.

The models are structured in order to test the independent and relative contributions of different attitudinal variables:

Model 1 establishes a baseline by regressing far-right voting on established individual-level predictors: education, household income, employment status, anti-immigration attitudes, political trust, and age, with country fixed effects.

Model 2 adds the hostile sexism index to the baseline to capture the association between hostile gender attitudes and far-right support as documented in prior literature.

Model 3 replaces hostile sexism with the economic gender attitudes index, testing whether gendered economic attitudes predict far-right voting independently of the standard predictors.

Model 4 includes both indices simultaneously, provided that multicollinearity diagnostics permit their joint inclusion.

All four models are presented side by side to facilitate comparison of coefficient magnitudes and model fit statistics (AIC, log-likelihood). The key comparison is between Models 2, 3, and 4: whether economic gender attitudes add predictive power beyond hostile sexism, and whether the hostile sexism coefficient attenuates when economic gender attitudes are introduced. Such attenuation would be consistent with the theoretical claim that hostile sexism is partly a downstream expression of perceived economic threat from gender equality.

Analysis and results

After subsetting the data, encoding the variables, and preparing the data for modelling, the final sample size was N = 1486 and included data from 23 countries, countries with zero young males reporting a vote for the far-right (GB and LT) have been excluded. Among the sampled young men, 238 reported voting for a far-right party in their country, representing 15.1% of the total sample. For the composite variables (indices) I constructed, Cronbach’s alpha of less than 0,70 is reported for the gendered economic attitudes index, which showed only modest internal consistency. For other index variables, Cronbach’s alpha exceeded 0,70, showing strong internal consistency.

To avoid possible multicollinearity and study the association between hostile sexism and gendered

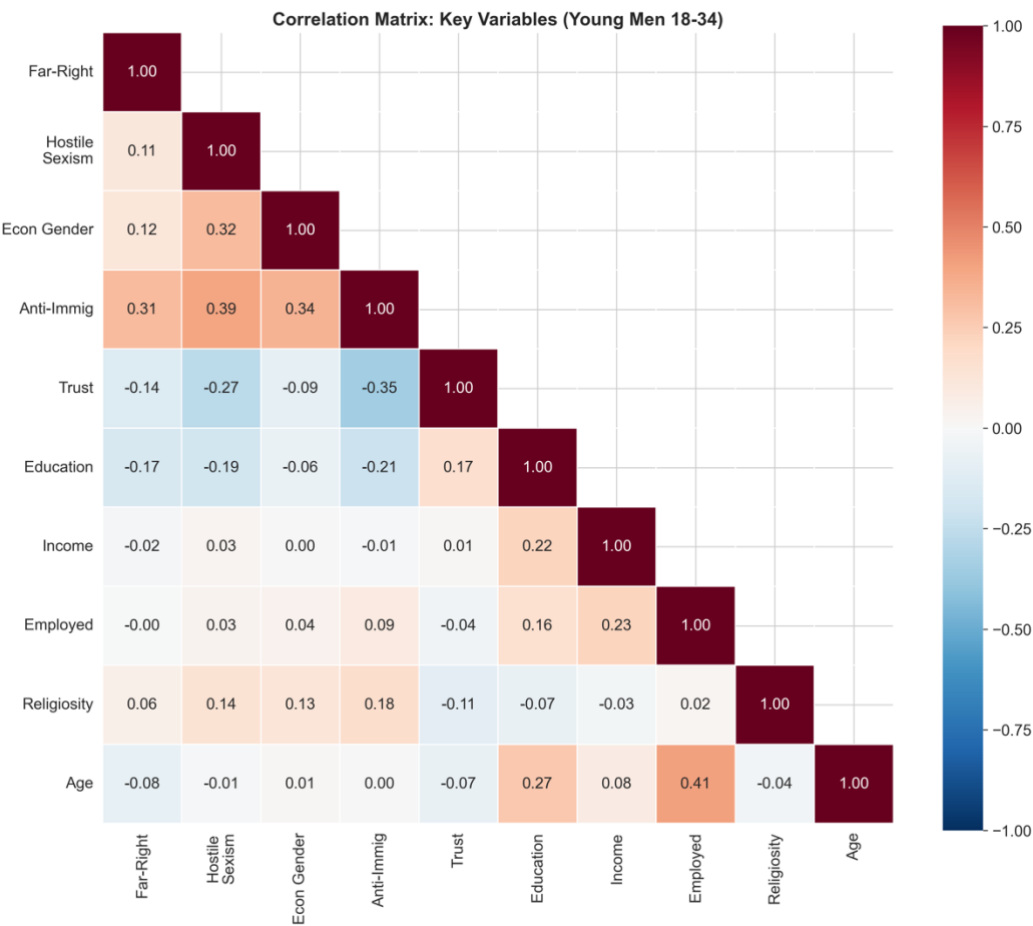


Figure 1: Correlation matrix

economic attitudes, I built a correlation matrix of the key variables that I planned to include in the model (Figure 1) and the outcome — far-right vote. For far-right vote, the strongest bivariate association is with anti-immigration attitudes at $r = 0.31$. That is clearly the largest relationship in the matrix for the outcome, and substantively it makes sense: among young men in your sample, stronger anti-immigration sentiment is the variable most closely aligned with far-right voting. The

Table 1: Logit Models of Far-Right Voting Among Young Males

	Baseline	+ HS	+ EGA	Full Model
Hostile sexism		0.103 (0.115)		0.083 (0.126)
Economic gender attitudes			0.111 (0.089)	0.098 (0.096)
Anti-immigration	1.204*** (0.150)	1.178*** (0.152)	1.173*** (0.154)	1.156*** (0.155)
Political trust	-0.111 (0.075)	-0.108 (0.076)	-0.112 (0.076)	-0.109 (0.078)
Education	-0.122* (0.063)	-0.116* (0.062)	-0.123* (0.064)	-0.119* (0.063)
Income	0.008 (0.044)	0.007 (0.043)	0.009 (0.044)	0.008 (0.043)
Employed	-0.029 (0.246)	-0.026 (0.244)	-0.034 (0.241)	-0.032 (0.240)
Age	-0.048 (0.029)	-0.048 (0.029)	-0.047 (0.029)	-0.048 (0.029)
Religiosity	0.080 (0.112)	0.082 (0.113)	0.071 (0.110)	0.074 (0.110)
Urban	-0.483*** (0.171)	-0.479*** (0.170)	-0.478*** (0.175)	-0.476*** (0.174)
Observations	1486	1486	1486	1486
Pseudo R^2	0.254	0.254	0.255	0.255
Country FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Clustered SEs	Country	Country	Country	Country

Notes: Logit coefficients reported. Country fixed effects are included in all models but omitted from the table. Clustered standard errors are shown in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

most intriguing feature of the predictor list seen in the matrix is that the attitudinal variables group together. Hostile sexism is correlated with anti-immigration at 0.39, and economic gender conservatism is correlated with anti-immigration at 0.34 and hostile sexism at 0.32. This suggests that these variables are tapping into overlapping but distinct aspects of a broader worldview. In line with the expectations, political trust stands out as negatively linked to several ideological predictors: -0.35 with anti-immigration and -0.27 with hostile sexism. Among the controls, the largest coefficient in the whole matrix is age and employment, $r = 0.41$. Within an 18–34 sample, that is totally plausible. From a modelling perspective, this matrix suggests no severe multicollinearity problem. This claim is also justified by the Variance Inflation factor values below 1,5 for all variables.

The results of the regression analysis (Table 1) clearly show that anti-immigration attitudes is the strongest and most consistent predictor of far-right voting among young men across all model

specifications. By contrast, hostile sexism and economic gender attitudes do not reach conventional levels of statistical significance once standard controls and country fixed effects are included in the model. However, both coefficients remain positive, which is directionally consistent with the theoretical expectation. Overall, the findings indicate that the three hypotheses are not supported in their strong form: economic gender attitudes do not exhibit an independent association with far-right voting after controlling for established predictors, nor do they remain statistically significant when hostile sexism is included in the full model. Thus, the results obtained from these data with my operationalization of variables and model specification do not support the argument that gendered economic perceptions are independently associated with the choice to vote for a far-right party in elections. Still, this does not necessarily mean that the hypothesis is entirely invalid, as the proposed relationship may be supported when tested in particular national contexts with certain characteristics. On this basis, I suggest that the relationship between gendered economic perceptions and far-right voting may be context-dependent. Previous studies have already shown that the determinants of far-right voting may vary across countries and political contexts. In addition, because support for gender equality is often considered more socially desirable in many European countries, young men may be reluctant to disclose their true attitudes. For this reason, testing country-level predictors that capture structural conditions related to the decline of male privilege and women's dependence on partners or husbands may be a productive avenue for further research on young males' pro-far-right voting. The examination of the propensity to vote for far-right parties, as well as alignment with their policy positions, also represents a promising direction for future research.

Several other limitations must be understood when interpreting these results. Firstly, the study is based on cross-sectional data and hence cannot inform about causality. Secondly, the economic gender attitudes index has limited internal consistency, which might affect the strength of the effect. It indicates that the measure of the underlying construct is imperfect. Thirdly, the mechanism that has been discussed in this paper is structural in nature, whereas the empirical analysis relies on individual-level attitudinal proxies. Nevertheless, the study makes a contribution by showing that the growing far-right appeal among young European men, when studied cross-sectionally, cannot be explained through gendered economic perceptions as measured here. In this sense, the paper's main contribution lies not in closing the debate, but in clarifying where the next stage of research on young men and far-right politics in Europe should begin and where it shouldn't.

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Appendix

Countries coded as far-right:

Austria — FPÖ

Belgium — Vlaams Belang

Bulgaria — Vazrazhdane (Revival)

Croatia — Domovinski pokret

Cyprus — ELAM

Estonia — EKRE

Finland — Finns Party

France — Rassemblement National (RN); Reconquête

Germany — Alternative für Deutschland (AfD)

Greece — Elliniki Lysi

Italy — Fratelli d'Italia (FdI); Lega

Latvia — National Alliance

Lithuania — National Alliance

Montenegro — Movement for Changes (Pokret za promjene, PzP), Za budućnost Crne Gore (Nova srpska demokratija, Demokratska narodna partija Crne Gore)

Netherlands — PVV; Forum voor Democratie (FvD); JA21

Norway — Progress Party (FrP)

Poland — Konfederacja; Prawo i Sprawiedliwość (PiS)

Portugal — Chega

Serbia — Srpska radikalna stranka

Slovakia — ĽS Naše Slovensko (ĽSNS); SME Rodina

Slovenia — SDS; NSi – Nova Slovenija – Krščanski demokrati; Slovenska Nacionalna Stranka

Spain — Vox

Sweden — Sweden Democrats

Switzerland — SVP; Federal Democratic Union (EDU); Ticino League (Lega dei Ticinesi, LdT);

Movement of the Citizens of French-speaking Switzerland

United Kingdom — Reform UK (Brexit Party); UK Independence Party (UKIP)

Script (Data transformation and modelling) and Data:

<https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1vaHTrnD5AG6ndR4JEVE7FyI5AQXPOYjE?usp=sharing>

Declaration of Originality

I hereby declare that I have written this seminar paper on my own, have not used any sources or aids other than those specified, and have marked the passages taken from them as such. All aids used are listed in the table below. Regarding the use of Large Language Models (LLM, e.g. Chat-GPT), I have archived the entire LLM interaction history with reference to the submitted work and can present it upon request. This seminar paper has not been presented in this or a similar form in any other course.

Name of Aid/Tool

Tools

Claude AI (LLM), DeepL

Purpose

Language translation, grammar/vocabulary improvements, coding assistance (search for functions and methods)